

THEM PROBLEM

RESPOND VS. REACT:
THE CHOICE THAT
CHANGES EVERYTHING



EXTERNAL NOISE IS ALWAYS GOING TO BE THERE. THE CHOICE IS WHAT YOU DO WITH IT.

THE SERIES

FIVE LESSONS. ONE PLAYER.

01

Respond vs. React: The Choice That Changes Everything

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02

The Coach's Yell: What It Mean and What it Doesn't

Coming up.

03

eammates and the Noise They Carry

Coming up.

04

The Parent Sideline: Your Noise is Her Input

Coming up.

05

Off The Court: Carrying Clarity Into Life

Coming up.

HEAR THIS ONCE

EVERY ATHLETE HAS LET A COACH'S
YELL, A TEAMMATE'S LOOK, OR A
SIDELINE NOISE IMPACT HER NEXT PLAY.
THAT IS A CHOICE, EVEN WHEN IT
DOESN'T FEEL LIKE ONE.

Those moments are moments where you have a decision: let them define you or let them pass through. That is not a personality trait. It is a trainable skill. And it begins with understanding that external noise is not your job to carry.

— EXTERNAL NOISE IS NOT YOUR JOB · MAZEPERFORMANCE

THE NOISE MODEL

JUST BECAUSE SOMEONE ELSE HAS AN
OPINION DOESN'T MEAN IT APPLIES TO
YOU. YOU HAVE THE CHOICE TO RESPOND
OR REACT.

→ React: the noise lands and you play through it, under it, or against it

→ Respond: the noise is acknowledged and deliberately set aside before the next play

→ The practice: choose response before the match, not during it

— OTHER PEOPLE'S OPINIONS ARE NOT YOUR JOB. YOUR NEXT PLAY IS.

05 · THE BREAKDOWN

WHAT CARRIES NOISE

COACH ENERGY

A yell, a disappointed look, a correction in the wrong tone, all carry emotional weight onto the court.

TEAMMATE SIGNALS

A look, a sigh, a dropped head, interpreted in fractions of a second and acted on.

SIDELINE

Parent energy, stranger reactions, crowd noise, all present, all optional to absorb.



BUILDING THE CHOICE

IN PRACTICE

After any external noise moment in practice, ask: 'What did you choose to do with that?'

WATCH FOR

The plays that follow external noise, do they get better, worse, or stay the same?

THE SHIFT

From absorbing noise automatically to having a deliberate process for choosing what enters the system.



07 · REMEMBER THIS

SAVE THIS · COME BACK TO IT

EVERY PIECE OF EXTERNAL NOISE IS
AN INVITATION TO REACT. YOU DON'T
HAVE TO ACCEPT EVERY INVITATION.

SAVE THIS. COME BACK TO IT.

THIS WEEK

THIS WEEK, TRACK ONE NOISE RESPONSE.

- ✓ After the next practice or match, identify one moment of external noise
- ✓ Ask: 'Did you react or respond? What was the difference?'
- ✓ Practice the response before it's needed: what do you do in the three seconds after noise arrives?
- ✓ Build a deliberate routine for the noise moment, breath, cue word, next play



THEM PROBLEM

THE COACH'S YELL:
WHAT IT MEANS
AND WHAT IT DOESN'T

02

SHE IS NOT YELLING AT YOU. SHE IS COACHING THE MOMENT.

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ATHLETES WHO TAKE COACHING
PERSONALLY PLAY WITH A DIVIDED
NERVOUS SYSTEM, ONE PART PLAYING,
ONE PART MANAGING THE EMOTIONAL
AFTERMATH OF FEEDBACK.

Most coaches are not attacking the athlete. They are responding to the moment. The athlete who can separate 'that was directed at the play' from 'that was directed at me' has a performance advantage that most athletes never develop.

— THE COACH IS COACHING THE MOMENT · MAZEPERFORMANCE

THE DEPERSONALIZATION TOOL

WHEN THE COACH YELLS, THE FASTEST
RESET IS THE SIMPLEST ONE: IT'S ABOUT
THE PLAY, NOT ABOUT YOU.

- The coach's emotional intensity is usually proportional to the tactical moment, not the athlete's worth
- Taking coaching personally creates a second emotional event on top of the first one
- Depersonalization is not suppression — it's clarity about what the moment is actually about

— THE PLAY HAPPENED. THE COACHING HAPPENED. BOTH ARE DONE. NEXT PLAY.

05 · THE BREAKDOWN

THE TWO EVENTS

EVENT ONE

The mistake on the court, real, observed, finished.

EVENT TWO

The coaching response, real, received, also finished.

THE THIRD EVENT

The interpretation: 'She hates me. I'm getting benched. I can't do anything right.' This one is optional.



CUTTING THE THIRD EVENT

IN PRACTICE

After a correction, the only job is the next play. Everything else is noise.

WATCH FOR

Whether your athlete replays coaching moments rather than moving forward.

THE SHIFT

From processing the coach's response emotionally to processing it tactically, what do I do differently next time?



07 · REMEMBER THIS

SAVE THIS COME BACK TO IT

THE PLAY HAPPENED. THE COACHING
HAPPENED. BOTH ARE DONE. YOUR
ONLY JOB NOW IS THE NEXT PLAY.

SAVE THIS. COME BACK TO IT.

THIS WEEK

THIS WEEK, PRACTICE CUTTING THE THIRD EVENT.

✓ After the next coaching moment your athlete receives, ask: 'What was the tactical message?'

✓ Then ask: 'What is the next play?'

✓ Practice moving between these two questions without stopping at the emotional interpretation

✓ Track whether her recovery speed from coaching moments improves over four weeks

THEM PROBLEM

TEAMMATES AND
THE NOISE THEY CARRY

03

HER TEAMMATES' EMOTIONS ARE NOT HERS TO MANAGE. HER OWN ARE.



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ATHLETES SPEND ENORMOUS ENERGY
MANAGING THE EMOTIONS OF THEIR
TEAMMATES, TAKING ON THEIR
FRUSTRATION, ABSORBING THEIR BODY
LANGUAGE, REACTING TO THEIR
RESPONSES.

You are responsible for your own emotional state on the court. You are not responsible for your teammates'. The athlete who has clear boundaries around emotional responsibility plays with more freedom.

— YOUR RESPONSIBILITY IS YOUR STATE · MAZEPERFORMANCE

THE RESPONSIBILITY BOUNDARY

YOU ARE RESPONSIBLE FOR YOUR ENERGY,
YOUR FOCUS, AND YOUR CHOICES. YOUR
TEAMMATES' EMOTIONS ARE THEIRS TO
MANAGE.

→ Absorbing teammate frustration adds emotional load that does not belong to you

→ You can acknowledge a teammate's emotion without taking it on

→ Your job is to manage your own state so you show up for the team, not to manage theirs

— MANAGE YOUR STATE. TRUST YOUR TEAMMATES TO MANAGE THEIRS.

THE A B S O R P T I O N H A B I T

THE LOOK

A teammate drops her head after a mistake. You feel responsible for her. Your game changes.

THE ENERGY

A teammate is nervous, loud, or angry before a big match. You absorb it without meaning to.

THE BOUNDARY

You can support a teammate without carrying her emotional state, those are different things.



SUPPORT WITHOUT ABSORPTION

IN PRACTICE

After a teammate's mistake, the support move is one word, one nod, then back to your own focus.

WATCH FOR

Whether your athlete's game changes after a teammate's mistake, that's the absorption signal.

THE SHIFT

From being a sponge for everyone's emotions to being a steady presence for the team.



SAVE THIS COME BACK TO IT

SUPPORT YOUR TEAMMATES. BUT DON'T
CARRY WHAT ISN'T YOURS. YOUR STEADY
GAME IS THE MOST USEFUL THING YOU
CAN OFFER.

SAVE THIS. COME BACK TO IT.

THIS WEEK

THIS WEEK, PRACTICE ONE BOUNDARY IN TEAM SETTINGS.

- ✓ After the next practice, ask: 'Did you absorb anyone else's emotional state today?'
- ✓ Identify the moment it happened and what the trigger was
- ✓ Practice the response: acknowledge without absorbing, one nod, then refocus on your own game
- ✓ Track whether her own performance consistency improves as absorption decreases



THEM PROBLEM

THE PARENT SIDELINE:
YOUR NOISE IS HER INPUT



WHAT YOU SAY, DO, AND SIGNAL FROM THE STANDS IS NOISE SHE HAS TO MANAGE MID-MATCH.



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PARENTS SHOW UP TO SUPPORT
THEIR ATHLETES. SOME OF THE
NOISE THEY CREATE IS THE HARDEST
NOISE THEIR ATHLETE HAS TO
MANAGE.

Your voice, your body, your emotional reaction from the stands, all of it reaches your daughter mid-play. The athlete who has to manage parent energy during competition is an athlete playing at partial capacity.

— YOUR SIDELINE ENERGY IS HER NOISE · MAZEPERFORMANCE

THE SIDELINE AUDIT

YOUR PRESENCE AT HER MATCHES IS NOT NEUTRAL. EVERY SIGNAL YOU SEND IS SOMETHING SHE HAS TO MANAGE OR IGNORE.

→ Audible instructions compete with her coach's instructions, creating split focus

→ Visible reactions become data points she interprets in real time

→ The parent who manages their own sideline energy is giving their athlete the gift of focus

— THE BEST SIDELINE PARENT IS THE ONE HER ATHLETE DOESN'T HAVE TO THINK ABOUT MID-MATCH.

SIDELINE SIGNALS

AUDIBLE

Instructions, corrections, or commentary spoken during play, heard even when you think they aren't.



VISUAL

Head shakes, pacing, leaving early, visible frustration, processed in fractions of a second.

ENERGY

The overall emotional tone you bring: calm, anxious, reactive, is transmitted without words.



THE SIDELINE STANDARD

IN PRACTICE

At the next match, commit to: no audible instructions, neutral body language, consistent presence.

WATCH FOR

Your own emotional surges during tight moments, notice them before they become signals.

THE SHIFT

From being emotionally present for yourself to being energetically steady for her.



07 · REMEMBER THIS

SAVE THIS · COME BACK TO IT

YOUR ATHLETE SHOULD BE ABLE TO
LOOK INTO THE STANDS AND FIND
CALM, NOT ANOTHER PROBLEM TO
MANAGE.

SAVE THIS. COME BACK TO IT.

THIS WEEK

THIS WEEK, COMMIT TO THE SIDELINE STANDARD.

✓ At the next match: no audible instructions, neutral body, steady presence

✓ If you feel an emotional surge, name it privately and choose not to signal it

✓ After the match, ask your athlete: 'How did my energy feel from the stands today?'

✓ Accept the feedback — even if it's uncomfortable



THEM PROBLEM

OFF THE COURT:
CARRYING CLARITY
INTO LIFE

OS

THE SKILL OF CHOOSING YOUR RESPONSE TO EXTERNAL NOISE TRANSFERS EVERYWHERE.



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HEAR THIS ONCE

THE ATHLETE WHO LEARNS TO MANAGE
EXTERNAL NOISE ON THE VOLLEYBALL
COURT BECOMES THE ADULT WHO
MANAGES EXTERNAL NOISE AT WORK,
IN RELATIONSHIPS, AND IN LEADERSHIP.

Just because somebody else has an opinion doesn't mean it applies to you. On the court, in the car, in the office, in any room, this principle is the foundation of emotional freedom. And your athlete is building it now.

— EMOTIONAL FREEDOM IS THE REAL PRIZE · MAZEPERFORMANCE

THE TRANSFER

WHAT SHE IS BUILDING IN VOLLEYBALL IS NOT A SPORT SKILL. IT IS AN EMOTIONAL INTELLIGENCE SKILL, AND IT WILL SERVE HER FOR LIFE.

- The noise management skill transfers: criticism, judgment, peer pressure, social media
- The response-over-react skill transfers: workplace feedback, relationship conflict, public pressure
- The boundary skill transfers: knowing what is hers to carry and what is not

— EMOTIONAL FREEDOM IS NOT ABOUT CONTROL. IT IS ABOUT CHOICE.

05 · THE BREAKDOWN

THE LIFE TRANSFER

SOCIAL PRESSURE

When her peers are making choices she doesn't align with, this is external noise. Same skill.

CRITICISM

When a teacher, boss, or friend delivers harsh feedback, respond or react. Same choice.

SELF-KNOWLEDGE

Knowing what fills her tank, and making choices based on that, is the cornerstone of adult clarity.



THE EXPLICIT TRANSFER

IN PRACTICE

After a noise management success on the court, ask: 'Where else in your life could you use this skill this week?'

WATCH FOR

Whether she can transfer the skill independently, that's the sign it's becoming hers.

THE SHIFT

From 'I'm doing this for volleyball' to 'I'm building this for my whole life.'



07 · REMEMBER THIS

SAVE THIS COME BACK TO IT

THE ATHLETE WHO KNOWS WHAT IS
HERS TO CARRY AND WHAT IS NOT
BECOMES THE ADULT WHO MOVES
THROUGH THE WORLD WITH CLARITY.

SAVE THIS. COME BACK TO IT.

THIS WEEK

THIS WEEK, NAME ONE LIFE TRANSFER.

✓ After a noise management moment on the court this week, make the transfer explicit

✓ 'That same skill, what did you do with the noise, applies when a friend pressures you too.'

✓ Let her make the connection herself if she can; guide her there if she can't

✓ Celebrate when the skill shows up outside the gym, that's the real win

